



Grassroots exchange: New Zealand's senior women cricketers share catching drills and laughter with young players at Devapathiraja College in Rathgama, one of Sri Lanka's key nurseries for emerging women cricketers. [X/@WHITE_FERNS](#)

Siriwardene adds.

"We have quite a decent system in Sri Lanka. School cricket is picking up, and solid coaches are entering the fray. We have solid Under-17s, U-19s, and emerging A teams that are getting more opportunities," former cricketer Hashan Tillakaratne, who has coached both Sri Lanka and Bangladesh in recent years, tells *Sportstar*.

His optimism is reflected in the U-19 side's 5-0 T20 whitewash over a touring Australian outfit. "There was a time when we were struggling to put the side together; now you have some of these girls in the rankings. It's a definite step up," he says.

Colleges such as Devapathiraja College in Rathgama, the hometown of breakout all-rounder Kavisha Dilhari, are now central to nurturing Sri Lanka's best talent. SLC has even facilitated occasional exposure tours where visiting international teams train and interact with these players.

Kavisha herself embodies a system that has finally begun to produce talent rather than merely chase parity. She benefited from the Foundation of Goodness (FOG), a social non-profit co-founded by Kushil Gunasekera and Muttiah Muralitharan that now supports sporting talent. Several national players have risen through its grassroots programs, making FOG a pillar of Sri Lanka's sporting ecosystem.

Its work has drawn support from Surrey Cricket Club, the Marylebone Cricket Club, various Australian academies, and even pop star Bryan Adams, who contributed to building facilities on the island.

"That Asia Cup win definitely did something here in mushrooming interest in the women's game. So many girls from rural areas suddenly emerged wanting to play like Chamari, Kavisha, and Harshitha. Our job then becomes to ensure there are facilities for these dreams," Gunasekera tells *Sportstar*.

The ground in Seenigama, Gunasekera's native village, now serves as FOG's High-Performance hub. Its scouting camps reach across the country in search of players to feed into the national structure. FOG has built playgrounds in several

villages and hopes to expand further into the northern province and the central tea-estate regions.

Bridging the gap

Even as Sri Lanka's system grows, the gap between the senior team and its feeder tiers remains an uncomfortable truth.

Rathnayake is blunt: "It's a concern. I won't lie, but this is what I have." A large part of the issue lies in exposure. Like many 'smaller' cricketing nations, Sri Lanka rarely plays top-tier opposition. Before this World Cup, the team had not faced Australia in an ODI since 2019 — and that meeting was eventually washed out. "We were not often given the chance to compete against those teams. We did have the opportunity to play India in the Asia Cups and Asian Games, but encountered the others only during ICC events. In my 17-year career, I participated in just one bilateral series with Australia," Siriwardene says.

Sri Lanka's first win of the tournament came in a scrappy match against Bangladesh, a contest where the team that made fewer mistakes prevailed. It was sealed by yet another Athapaththu masterclass: three wickets for one run in the final over when Bangladesh needed nine to win. For now, the senior side and its management will reflect on a difficult campaign before resuming domestic duties.

At the time of writing, Sri Lanka's World Cup has been shaped as much by the weather as by form, with three of its five Colombo fixtures affected by rain. So much for home advantage. The rains have also dampened attendance. SLC announced free entry at the R. Premadasa Stadium and refunds for those who had already paid. Crowds, mostly families from the surrounding Maligawatta suburb, made an evening of it regardless.

One fan summed it up best: "Things in Sri Lankan cricket always happen as miracles. Look at Chamari!"

For years, sparks of brilliance have kept the women's game alive on this island. The challenge now is to turn those sparks into a steady flame.